ceremonial functions, it seemed to him that it was the beginning of the end of his presidency. It looked as if Eisenhower and Republicans such as Senator Keating had been right all along. “You still think the fuss about Cuba is unimportant?” Kennedy asked his appointments secretary and confidant Kenneth O’Donnell during a break between his morning meetings. “Absolutely,” responded O’Donnell. “The voters won’t give a damn about Cuba.” When Kennedy shared the news of the missiles, O’Donnell was incredulous. ‘I don’t believe it,” he told the president. “You better believe it,” Kennedy fired back. “Ken Keating will probably be the next president of the United States.”[7]

The meeting of top foreign policy and security advisers called to assess the new intelligence information on Cuba and advise the president on a course of action began in the Cabinet Room of the West Wing at 11:50 a.m. Around the table, apart from the president himself, were Bobby Kennedy, McGeorge Bundy, Robert McNamara, Dean Rusk, and top figures from the State and Defense departments. John McCone, the CIA director, who had missed key meetings on Cuba in September, was absent again, and once again the cause of his absence had to do with his new family. His wife’s son by her first marriage, and now his stepson, had died in a race-car crash, and McCone had to attend the funeral. He would be back in DC the next day, but for now the CIA was represented by McCone’s deputy, General Marshall Carter.[8]

“There’s a medium-range ballistic missile launch site,” said Carter, who began his presentation by showing the president a U-2 photo. His words were saved for posterity by the secret recording system that Kennedy had installed in his Cabinet Room and had now activated. He had begun taping meetings with his advisers in the late summer of 1961. The top-secret project was probably launched with an eye to helping the president keep track of his decisions and advice given by others, as well as the possible preparation of another autobiographical book. “How do you know this is a medium-range ballistic missile?” Kennedy asked those present at the meeting. “The length, Sir,” answered Arthur Lundahl, the founding director of the National Photographic Interpretation Center, who was assisting Carter with the presentation. His photogrammetrist had measured the